



and Muslims rooted for the Muslim XI) was an anathema. The Ranji Trophy, which gradually replaced the Pentangular as India's premier first class competition was broadly based on the territorial principle: teams generally represented provinces, though some represented cities and others erstwhile princely states. One or two teams represented all-India organisations like the Railways and the Services. Communal representation was rigorously avoided.

In contrast, the other nation carved out of British India, Pakistan, had no such difficulties with the idea of a Muslim team. Its first captain, Abdul Hafeez Kardar, saw Pakistan's Test team as a Muslim side, representing a new Muslim nation. He saw its victories as a vindication of

open to talent as cricket. Nor is it a coincidence that cricket and Hindi cinema are governed by a measurable ideal of performance and merit: namely, sporting results and the bottom line. Two reasons why cricket has been successfully used by filmmakers to make inspirational films like *Lagaan* and *Iqbal* are that Indian cricket has been properly representative of India's diversity, and that the game has come to symbolise the possibility of massive success through merit. *Lagaan* isn't exactly realist, but it is plausible in a rhetorical way because the rustics who taken on the colonial state at cricket and win, are no more diverse than India's real cricket teams, both past and present. Similarly, *Iqbal*'s feel-good idea that a deaf boy from India's rural hinterland can, with

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Compared to the great social moulds that shape us, cricket is trivial. It creates no solidarities; it only provides an arena in which to rehearse the solidarities that already exist.

SPORT AS INSPIRATION: The game symbolises the possibility of success through merit

Pakistan's existence. Cricket, like all team sport, reflected the ideological fashions of the day.

In apartheid South Africa, Coloureds and Blacks were excluded from international cricket and played in segregated teams. Till well into the 20th century, first-class cricket in England faithfully mirrored the class divisions and prejudices of the time. Amateurs and professionals were known as Gentlemen and Players. The greatest batsman of his time, Jack Hobbs, never captained England because he was a professional. It was not till 1952 that a professional, Len Hutton, led England out. It took a war, a Labour victory and the welfare state to accomplish that.

Has Indian cricket been a good citizen? If we don't make the mistake of seeing it as an agent of a virtuous patriotism, the answer is yes. It would have been an even better citizen if it had won more often, but in every other respect Indian teams have been models of republican propriety. Their selection has sometimes drawn the charge of regional parochialism but never the more serious allegation of sectarian partiality. The captains have spanned the rainbow spectrum of Indian diversity: Christian, Sikh, Muslim and Hindu.

Outside the film industry, there's no other part of India's public life that has had careers as

unswerving commitment and some luck, make it to the Indian team, succeeds in getting the audience to suspend disbelief because cricket has, specially in recent times, seen young men from the mofussil (Virendra Sehwag, M.S. Dhoni, Munaaf Patel), do something nearly as unlikely in real life.

Even here, fans of the game oughtn't get carried away. No sport can transcend the society in which it is played. Cricket is an enormously popular game and after the television explosion of the 1990s, it's on the way to becoming India's mass sport, but a quick census of international players will show that unlike hockey, for example, it doesn't represent India's considerable tribal population nor, in significant numbers, its Dalits. Still, as a totem of India's pluralism, cricket does its job admirably. Stern critics will sometimes reproach us for celebrating Patel or Irfan Pathan not as players but as representatives of minorities. And the criticism is well meant because sportsmen should be singled out for their abilities, not their identities. But it is inevitable that a complex society like India with a history scarred by sectarian conflict, will anxiously look for symptoms of sickness or signs of good health. In this context the success of Patel and Pathan takes on a meaning larger than its sporting significance: alongside being good players, they'll become good omens.



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